EXHIBITION ▼

COUNTRY ON A CANVAS

ICONIC AT DAG DELHI BRINGS TOGETHER THREE CENTURIES OF INDIAN ART

The fifth edition of DAG's annual *Iconic: Masterpieces of Indian Modern Art* is underway at the New Delhi gallery. It explores the evolution of Indian art as it transitioned from the pre-modern era into modernity. The oldest work on display is from 1798 while the latest is from 2011.

***Iconic* includes the works of Anglo-Indian artists like Thomas Daniell, Charles D'Oyly and Marius Mauer, alongside 'Company painting' artists like Sita Ram. Amrita Sher-Gil is one of the nine 'National Treasure' artists showcased, and the only extant sculpture she ever created is there too. Dozens of major Indian artists are on display, including S.H. Raza, M.F. Husain, Chittaprosad Bhattacharya, Satish Gujral, Shanti Dave, et al. One of the crown jewels is a late 18th-early 19th century scroll of the *Bhagavata Purana*, comprised of 76 miniature paintings illustrating the complete text of the Purana, 18,000 verses in total.**

A circle with three dots within it has been used as a symbol for *Iconic*. It was drawn by the Russian artist Nicholas Roerich (1874-1947) as part of his illustration for the 'Banner of Peace' in the 1930s.

The exhibition is suited to both beginners and aficionados. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha
The exhibition is on till Jan. 30



Watercolour paintings from 19th century Kolkata, often made on cheap paper



IN CUSTODY Anju Dodiya's *Witness* (watercolour, charcoal and soft pastel on fabric)

EXHIBITION ▼

The Way of Trees

ANJU DODIYA's solo show in Mumbai explores vulnerability, imagination and the self

Anju Dodiya has an ongoing solo show at Chemould Prescott Road that comprises large-scaled colour infused fabric panels as well as a few works on paper. *The Geometry of Ash* touches upon the tragic legacies of disappearing trees while creating narratives around ancestral logs and stoic women who march on with resilience. Watercolour and charcoal are the primary mediums through which she weaves storytelling in her works.

On the subject of storytelling, it must be said that it is a powerful tool in her visuals and it is important to her. "Staining the fabric and the construct of the figures with charcoal, the harshness of the line... Narratives are imagined, constructed, stumbled upon. They are a take-off point for imagining, for the viewer and me, rather than stories carved in stone," she says. Indeed, the Mumbai-based artist is known for her layered narratives that explore vulnerability, imagination, and the theatre of the self.

Writer and curator Anish Gawande, who works at the intersection of culture, technology and politics with a strong emphasis on gender and sexuality in South Asia, believes that Anju speaks of stillness not as passivity, but as resistance. "In an age of urgency, of constant outrage and digital noise, her paintings compel us to pause. They demand attention, not consumption. They refuse polemic, yet they are political in the deepest sense—offering space for reflection when space itself feels endangered," he states in a note from the gallery. ■

—Deepali Dhingra
The show is on till Dec. 26